22 Proverbs

The Oxford Advanced Learner's Dictionary (2015) defines a proverb as 'a well-known phrase or sentence that gives advice or says something that is generally true.' A proverb is also known as a saying, an adage or a maxim.

'Deeds, not words' is a phrase. It is a proverb that tells us that people judge us more by what we actually do (*deeds*) than by what we say (*words*). This is a proverb that has been born out of experience—people have found it to be generally true.

There is another form of this proverb that is a sentence:

'Actions speak louder than words.'

Since proverbs are born out of common experience, they contain much wisdom. They give us advice, which may also come in the form of a warning:

'Look before you leap.'

This proverb advises us to be careful—to think (*Look*) before we do something (*leap*), that is not to act hastily, because once we have done something, we cannot undo it no matter how sorry we may feel.

Proverbs, you must have noticed by now, are usually brief and precise. They do not use words unnecessarily. Their brevity or shortness also helps us to remember them easily, and so, they are popular or become so, depending on how well they express what is generally thought or believed.

Given below are a few well-known proverbs:

1. *Better late than never.*
   If you should do something, like a duty or keeping a promise, it is better to do it even if you are late in doing it rather than not doing it at all.

2. *Call a spade a spade.*
   To be honest and frank, and say exactly what you think. This proverb asks us not to be insincere and say something that we really do not mean.
3. *Do as you would be done by.*
   Treat or behave towards others just as you would like them to treat or behave towards you. If you would like others to treat you well, you must treat them well.
4. *Don't put the cart before the horse.*
   Do things in the right order. It is the horse that pulls the cart and not the cart the horse. So, the horse should be put before the cart.
5. *Empty vessels make the most sound.*
   In this proverb, 'vessels' means containers like buckets or pots made of some metal. If you strike such a container when it is empty, it will make more sound than when it is full of something. So also empty-headed persons, those who are least able to say or do anything useful or sensible, speak the most, that is, make the most 'sound'.
6. *Fortune favours the brave.*
   People, who have the courage to take a risk and do something, are the ones who are most often successful—fortune smiles on them.
7. *Never say die.*
   Never give up and stop trying. In this proverb, 'die' has been used in the sense of 'making an end or stopping'. 'While there is life, there is hope.'
8. *Practice makes perfect.*
   Only if you do a thing over and over again can you become good at it.
9. *Rome was not built in a day.*
   It takes a lot of time and effort to do something great and remarkable, just as it took centuries to build Imperial Rome. This proverb teaches us to be patient and to persevere if we want to do something worthwhile.
10. *Waste not, want not.*
    You should make the best use of what you have and then, later on you will not have to look for what you need. If you do not spend your money on things that you do not need, you will have enough to spend on what you need.

11. *Make hay while the sun shines.*

    'Hay' is grass that is mown or cut and then dried in the sun as fodder, that is food, for cattle, horses, etc. So, hay can be made only when the sun shines and gives enough heat to dry the cut grass. If one does not 'make hay while the sun shines', one might not be able to make hay at all, for it may rain or the weather may change. Similarly in life, we must never hesitate or delay when an opportunity to do something useful or worthwhile comes—we must act and act positively.

    Three similar proverbs are: (i) *Strike while the iron is hot*; (ii) *Never put off till tomorrow what you can do today*; (iii) *Gather ye rosebuds while ye may*.

12. *Too many cooks spoil the broth.*

    If more than one cook is asked to make the soup (broth = a thick soup made by boiling meat or fish and vegetables in water), there is bound to be confusion—they will disagree with one another as to how much of what is to be used and how and when. What this proverb means is that if too many people are put in charge of doing the same thing, there is bound to be confusion. Each person will have his own idea about how the thing should be done. They will interfere with each other and the work that needs to be done will never get done or will be done badly. The 'soup' that will finally come out of the kitchen will not be fit for eating.

    A similar Turkish proverb says: '*Two captains will sink a ship*.'

Under Group I is a number of proverbs. The meaning of each proverb is given under Group II. Try and match each proverb with its meaning. First write down a proverb in your exercise book, and then, below it, write its meaning.

Group I

1. Time and tide wait for no man.
2. Make haste, less speed.
3. One man's meat is another man's poison.
4. Heaven helps them who help themselves.
5. You may lead a horse to the water, but you cannot make him drink.
6. Those who live in glass houses should not throw stones.
7. It is never too late to mend.
8. The leopard cannot change his spots.
9. Prevention is better than cure.
10. Every cloud has a silver lining.

Group II

(a) If you have done something wrong or if you realize that your conduct is not what it should be, and you want to 'mend your ways', that is change and become a better person than what you are, you can always do so whenever you want. It is never too late to change yourself for the better.

(b) Man must work and make the effort himself if he wants to succeed. One must not be idle and blame God for not helping one.

(c) If you want to do something, then do it as soon as you get a chance to do it, for if you hesitate or waste time, you may not get a chance to act again. Time will not wait for you, nor will the tide come whenever you want so that you may set sail.

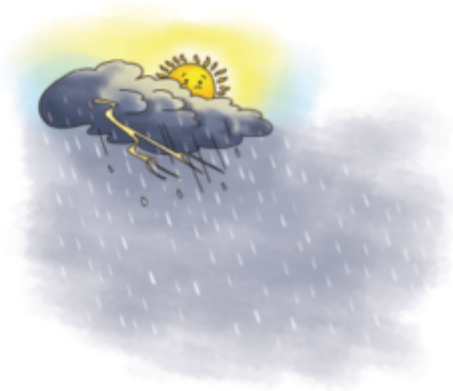
(d) You cannot force somebody to do something that he is determined not to do. Though you may try as hard as you can, he will always find a reason or an excuse not do it.

(e) If you think something bad is going to happen, it is always better to take steps to prevent it from happening rather than allowing the thing to happen and then trying to repair the damage done.

(f) If you try to do something in haste, you are more likely to make mistakes. This means that you have to do the same thing all over again. Your haste will only result in slowing you down.

(g) It is believed that one cannot change the character one is born with—a piece of coal will always be black no matter how much you wash it.

(h) One man may hate what another man likes—food that one likes may make another fall ill.

(i) All of us have some fault or the other. So, we should not be quick to point out the faults of others, for they can turn around and point out our faults. Do not throw a stone at somebody for he can always throw it back.

(j) Even when a dark cloud covers the sun, the edges (*lining*) of the cloud are bright because the sun is shining behind it. So also in life. There is no situation so hopeless that one cannot expect a change for the better to come soon.